the purpose. On other occasions he warned the French it would take nine nuclear bombs to destroy their country. Sir Frank was presumably too diplomatic to convey how many Soviet cities RAF Bomber Command was planning to incinerate in a nuclear war.

In diplomacy and statecraft, while words can be deeds, so deeds can be words. As Kennedy was delivering his televised address on 22 October, United States forces around the world were mobilising. Shortly before the President appeared on television, US conventional and nuclear forces began moving to Defense Condition (DEFCON) 3. The DEFCON readiness system comprised five levels. Even at the normal peacetime state of DEFCON-5, a proportion of US nuclear missiles and bombers were maintained on alert. Atlas and Titan ICBMs could be fired within fifteen minutes of a launch order; medium- and long-range B-47 Stratojet, B-52 Stratofortress, and B-58 Hustler bombers remained on ground alert, able to be aloft within fifteen minutes. A dozen B-52s were also on airborne alert as a safeguard against Soviet surprise attacks. Polaris SSBNs were at sea, able to fire their SLBMs when given the order. In Europe, Thor and Jupiter IRBMs were at fifteen-minutes readiness, with nuclear warheads mated to missiles. Thousands of other nuclear weapons in Europe and the Pacific and aboard five forward-deployed US aircraft carriers were likewise available.

With the declaration of DEFCON-3, 183 B-47 bombers dispersed to thirty-three military and civilian airfields across the United States; the overall number of strategic bombers on fifteen-minute ground alert rose from 652 to 912. Several hours prior to the President's speech, the US Air Defence Command dispersed its nuclear-armed interceptors; by the following morning, 161 F-101Bs, sixty-four F-106As, and thirty-one F-102As were on ground alert at sixteen bases across the northern United States. As the President delivered his speech, twenty-two fighters armed with Genie low-yield nuclear air-to-air missiles were patrolling the Florida coast. [12] In addition, by 23 October, three Polaris submarines were 'flushed' from Holy Loch in Scotland, adding to the six boats on station since mid-October.

DEFCON-3 was designed with the aim that 'no measures will be taken that could be considered provocative or that might disclose operational